Intersections, Integration, and Diversity: Multidimensional Perspectives on Film Studies

A Review of the International Young Scholars Forum at the Beijing International Film Festival's 29th Beijing College Student Film Festival

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With the arrival of the "post-cinema" era,[A] China's film industry and technologies have steadily matured, while domestic film studies has flourished through a lively plurality of approaches. Building on the methods, pathways, and paradigms of traditional film theory, rapid developments in media and digital technologies and mechanisms of film criticism emerging within new media contexts have brought opportunities and challenges to the theoretical perspectives, systematic frameworks, and cultural meanings of contemporary Chinese film studies. Against this background, outstanding young scholars have explored film theory and practice through intersecting methodologies, diverse perspectives on technological aesthetics, and integrated approaches to theoretical interpretation.

The International Young Scholars Forum was jointly hosted by Beijing Normal University and *Contemporary Cinema* and organized by the university's School of Arts and Communication and the organizing committee of the Beijing International Film Festival's 29th Beijing College Student Film Festival. *Film Review* and *New Films* provided academic support. Held online through Tencent Meeting under the theme "Intersections, Integration, and Diversity: Multidimensional Perspectives on Film Studies," the forum selected 38 outstanding papers by young scholars from China and abroad for presentation.

The final review panel comprised senior scholars and specialists: Yin Hong, professor at Tsinghua University's School of Journalism and Communication and distinguished professor and director of the Academy of Film at Macau University of Science and Technology; Yang Yuanying, professor and doctoral supervisor in the Department of Film Studies at Beijing Film Academy; Li Daoxin, associate dean, professor, and doctoral supervisor at Peking University's School of Arts and a distinguished professor under the Ministry of Education's Changjiang Scholars Program; Chen Yang, professor and doctoral supervisor in the School of Liberal Arts at Renmin University of China, director of its Film, Television, and Multimedia Arts Teaching and Research Section, and executive editorial board member of the university's reprinted-materials journal *Film and Television Arts*; Zhao Weifang, deputy director, research fellow, and doctoral supervisor at the Institute of Film and Television Research, Chinese National Academy of Arts; Zhang Guotao, research fellow and doctoral supervisor at the Communication University of China, executive director of its Center for Media Arts and Culture Research, and vice president and secretary-general of the China Collegial Association for Visual Art; Zhang Wenyan, deputy editor-in-chief and senior editor of *Contemporary Cinema*; and Lu Chunyan, Wang Yiwen, and Zhang Yan, professors and doctoral supervisors at Beijing Normal University's School of Arts and Communication. On the day of the forum, Lu Chunyan, Zhang Wenyan, Li Daoxin, and Chen Yang served as expert discussants, commenting on the papers and presentations.

The opening ceremony was chaired by Wang Yashu, lecturer at Beijing Normal University's School of Arts and Communication and deputy secretary-general of the festival's organizing committee. Opening addresses were delivered by Xiao Xiangrong, dean of the school and executive vice chair of the festival's organizing committee, and Huangfu Yichuan, president of *China Film News* and president and editor-in-chief of *Contemporary Cinema*. Four scholars, including Tan Qiuwen, senior editor of *Contemporary Cinema* and executive editor-in-chief of *Contemporary Animation*; Chen Yishui, lecturer in the school's Department of Digital Media, Zhongying Young Scholar, and Master's supervisor; and Shi Lin, lecturer at the school, served as academic moderators for the three parallel sessions.

I. Diverse Perspectives: New Phenomena in the Field of Cinema

Every stage of cinema's history has involved changes in technological aesthetics. Technology has continually driven the industry's renewal, exerting evident influence on production, exhibition, and viewing. The construction of technological-aesthetic approaches in film studies, the turn toward virtual reality, and new aesthetics all investigate the crossing and integration of boundaries between film technology and film texts, aesthetics, and markets. They also explore the relationship between technology and cinema and clarify its aesthetic implications and characteristics. These are pressing research concerns. Maintaining a rational, reflective approach and seeking a balance between technology and cinema, the young scholars discussed two perspectives: changes brought to cinema by new media technologies, and cultural meanings and identity expression in the post-cinema era.

Addressing technological changes, Lin Shuyu focused on “choice” in interactive narratives such as films and games, examining how their integration is achieved and using this as a point of departure for discussing media experiments in the digital age. Lin argued that, through limited choices within ergodic texts and repeated play, participants continually return to decisive moments of choice, approaching pure time itself as articulated in Deleuze's synthesis of time oriented toward the future. Sun Yanlin closely examined the operating strategies of the curated streaming platform MUBI from its foundation onward, seeking to enrich understandings of streaming business models and reconsider the future of cinema and film festivals. Yang Fusong investigated science-fiction humanism in the post-cinema era through technology, culture, and the body, asking how cinema, as a medium or art, can return to the human amid unprecedented technological development.

Yang Yu applied affect theory, originally developed in philosophy, to short-video studies. This offers possible directions for “the future of film studies” while activating the obscured affective potential of short-video imagery through attention to embodiment and interaction, providing a new way of understanding short videos. Tian Ye traced human-image relations to the pre-digital era and, within today's digital context, examined the “nomadic” subject in cinematic human-image relations. Distinguishing new relations from their traditional forms, Tian analyzed their effects on spectators' aesthetic formation and emotional experience. Luo Le identified the trajectories and characteristics of three principal stages in Macao cinema: the “active observer,” the “welcome other,” and the “growing self-narrator.” Drawing on cultural innovation theory, Luo proposed exploring “blue ocean” development strategies for the industry through differentiated, branded cultural expression.

Yang Han analyzed problems facing online film festivals and, through a case study of MUBI as an art-cinema streaming platform, explored the rationale and feasibility of curatorship as their core strategy. This inquiry into future directions enriches theoretical models in festival studies, particularly the “film festival circuit.” Li Zhiyi reviewed essay-film practice and scholarship, drawing out important insights from auteur theory concerning the film medium and considering the identity and position of cinema's “embodied enunciator” in the mobile-internet context.

Turning to cultural meanings and identity in post-cinema, Li Yanrui used textual analysis of zhiguai films, or films of strange and supernatural tales, to explore their significance for tracing and regenerating China's fine traditional culture. Zhang Cheng examined reciprocal influences between cinema and games, showing how interactive films develop distinct forms and aesthetic characteristics along different paths: full-motion video, chapter-based narratives, and new forms of interactive cinema. Xie Zhoupu examined the combination of computer-based and cinematic automatic mechanisms under media convergence. Observing how the repetition of computer programs produces repeated visual patterns, Xie sought possibilities for creators to reconfigure these “new automatic mechanisms” through their own agency.

Xu Xiaotang used material-discursive analysis and the concepts of “thingness” and “thing-power” to examine the reassertion of seemingly inert objects' subjectivity within VR imagery. Xu investigated how material forces shape VR's discursive expression and construct relations between things and humans in the viewing experience, arguing that an aesthetics of thingness and new human-thing relationships constitute VR image art's distinctive appeal. Gong Qili considered how gamified films can overcome the sense of repetition and contrivance within recurring loops, move beyond virtuality, reduce the obtrusiveness of complex game orders and rules, and produce immersion and verisimilitude. Lü Hongyan proposed that works combining cinema and video through the reformatting of cinema as short video constitute a new cinematic textual form and offer an alternative route to film experience. Drawing on spatial theory, Xu Ranran examined three spatial dimensions of the artistic expression of “demolition imagery” to reveal modern cities' external structures of reality and internal textures of psychic life.

II. Intersecting Paths: Methodologies of Film Studies

Behind China's ever-changing cinematic phenomena, theoretical research that reveals their underlying nature and patterns is an indispensable force in strengthening the immense undertaking of Chinese cinema. It is required by filmmaking and the industry and provides an important measure of an era's cinematic development. Constructing film theory demands both historically extensive knowledge and an innovative, contemporary perspective on developments in Chinese cinema. Under this theme, the young scholars explored intersecting methodologies through technology, media, culture, and aesthetics.

One focus was the historical development and historiographical transformations of contemporary cinema and media. Wang Yao incorporated the influence of dubbed foreign films into Chinese film history, opening a new area through the distinctive case of Romanian films dubbed in the People's Republic. Tang Ruo traced the disciplinary development of embodied cognition and conceptual metaphor theory alongside cognitive science's role in film studies. Tang proposed an interdisciplinary methodology for documentary research, examining bodily schemas and conceptual cognition arising from metaphors of perceptual thought. Kong Yuan summarized ethnographic modes of memory-writing in animated documentaries, drawing on cultural memory and trauma theories to examine their nationally and locally inflected expression in China. Taking Tibetan Buddhism, a major component of Tibetan culture, as a broad frame of reference, Yuan Mingze began with folk customs to trace Tibetan Buddhist art's history and stylistic development.

A second focus was theoretical construction around cultural forms and media transformations. Liu Runkun examined the micromechanisms through which rural film exhibition in the “Seventeen Years” period fostered social solidarity as an interaction ritual chain. Zhou Houyi employed genealogy to reconstruct a dynamic “prehistory” of changes in image ontology and media forms. Examining Chinese video-art history, Liao Ziyan identified the absence of an oppositional relationship to television as a factor shaping early creative motifs and development, preventing artists from adopting a radically forward-moving stance in experimental avant-garde production. Han Yudi clarified “social poetics” and interpreted “cultural

intimacy" and "iconic strategies" in documentary, identifying the dual value of social poetics for documentary research.

Liu Siyu investigated film collections' value attributes, historical significance, and interpretation to explore their relationships with the writing of film history, together with the significance, methods, and value of such research. In examining the "people-oriented character" of Chinese cinema, He Dongyu proposed introducing the Marxist method of "retrospective reflection" to enrich interdisciplinary dialogue and broaden the scope of Chinese film studies. Zhou Dayi explored how four elements - narrative content, racing culture, editing techniques, and collective experience - shape visual pleasure in motor-racing films.

III. Integrated Perspectives: Reinterpreting Film Theory

The advent of post-cinema and the rapid development of media are quietly transforming Chinese cinema's production technologies, industry, and cultural writing. Across changing research perspectives and historical contexts, new academic topics increasingly encounter established film scholarship. Young scholars are focusing on cinematic issues through integrated perspectives and proposing innovative theoretical interpretations.

One focus was media change and industrial integration. Zhang Shilin examined the technical and narrative attractions of the YMCA's visual materials and the modern field formed through cinematic media practice. Wei Jiani investigated film exhibition in Guiyang, within China's wartime hinterland during the War of Resistance against Japanese Aggression, 1937-1945. Reconstructing exhibition history and revealing its significance also constitutes a rediscovery of Chinese film history. Liu Baiqian integrated cinema, theatricality theory, film phenomenology, and modernist art. Through the relationship between absent actors and present spectators, Liu used cinema's detheatricalization to interpret film phenomenology and offer a route for reconsidering propositions in modernist art. Xuan Liqun examined vertical-screen production historically and in the present, explaining its historical legitimacy, aesthetic potential, and limitations, and discussing the dual effects of its proliferation in new media environments.

Another focus was conceptual change and theoretical reconstruction. Through the perspectives of "self-impregnation and self-reproduction" and "superimposition upon the land," Shang Wensiqi analyzed female characters across 1930s left-wing cinema, Seventeen Years cinema, scar cinema, and Fifth Generation cinema. Reconsidering the fixation on the screen figure of the "self-impregnating mother," this analysis reconfigured that female image. Qi Miaomiao analyzed modes of characterization in feminist film theory and the expression and development of "sisterhood" in films by Hong Kong women screenwriters and directors after 1997. Shi Yuchen examined film narrative under state discourse and changes in ideas of marriage during 1949-1966. Ruan Jiale surveyed contemporary "made-up faces," "cosmetic-surgery faces," and "beauty-filtered faces," using ideological criticism to reveal the significance of interactions among the face, media, and culture in the image age. Huang Tianle adopted interdisciplinary and intermedial perspectives to examine spatial similarities among pre-cinema, early cinema, and post-cinema, distinguishing connections between cinema, architecture, and spectators' bodily experience.

Throughout the online forum, the expert discussants offered valuable suggestions and professional commentary on the papers. The participating young scholars addressed frontier questions, proposed fresh arguments, revisited classic theories, and expanded research perspectives and methods, bringing renewed energy to film criticism and theory. Tan Qiuwen, senior editor of *Contemporary Cinema* and executive editor-in-chief of *Contemporary Animation*, chaired the closing ceremony. Chen Yang, professor, doctoral supervisor, and director of the Film and Television Teaching and Research Section in Renmin University's School of Liberal Arts, announced the ten outstanding papers selected by the expert review committee.

Note

{A} “Post-cinema” is a designation used by Western film scholars to theorize cinema's new forms, developments, and problems in the twenty-first century. Taking the digital age's impact on cinema as its central concern, post-cinema research actively responds to current and impending transformations of the film industry and the challenges they present to film studies, contributing to an emerging theoretical framework for film research in the digital age.

Terminology and Translation Notes

These notes are editorial additions to the translation, separate from the authors' report.

Chinese personal names are rendered in Hanyu Pinyin; “Lü” preserves the vowel distinction in the surname. Institutional positions and qualifications reproduce those reported in the 2022 article. “Seventeen Years” denotes 1949-1966 in Chinese film historiography. “Scar cinema” and “Fifth Generation cinema” retain established historical designations. Other key terms include post-cinema, technological aesthetics, ergodic text, affect theory, essay film, embodied enunciator, interaction ritual chains, genealogy, cultural intimacy, thing-power, and detheatricalization.

The original states that four scholars moderated three sessions but supplies only three names in that sentence. The translation preserves this by presenting the named scholars as an inclusive list. The unusual formulations “self-impregnation and self-reproduction” and “self-impregnating mother” reproduce the report's terminology rather than substituting a different theoretical concept.

The festival's English name was checked against the Beijing International Film Festival's own usage of “Beijing College Student Film Festival” (https://bjiff.com/Banner/202304/t20230405_145089.html). “Academy of Film” and Yin Hong's name follow Macau University of Science and Technology's institutional usage (https://www.must.edu.mo/id-13630/article/view/id-20725.html?locale=en_US). No new bibliography has been inserted into the forum report, which contains one original explanatory footnote and no reference list.